

the Peninsula to support the Union offensive in northern Virginia. The Confederates had a brief opportunity to seize the initiative before these reinforcements arrived. Leaving only a small force in front of Richmond, Lee moved most of his Army of Northern Virginia and joined Jackson at Gordonsville. After Pope's army fell back across the Rappahannock River, the Confederates embarked on a bold offensive. Facing a superior enemy—the Confederates were outnumbered by about 55,000 to 75,000—Lee divided his forces, gambling that Pope would not attack. On August 25, Jackson led his 24,000-strong corps on a march to the northwest and crossed the Rappahannock, swinging around the right flank of Pope's army. He then headed east through Thoroughfare Gap in the Bull Run Mountains, following the line of the railroad toward Manassas. His men marched 50 miles (80km) in two days. They captured Bristoe Station, wrecking trains and tearing up tracks, and then descended upon Manassas Junction, the main supply base for the Army of Virginia. The Confederates feasted on bacon and canned lobster, while Jackson resupplied his army with Union horses, artillery, and ammunition.

16,000 The estimated Union casualties in five days' fighting from August 27 to September 1, 1862—almost double the number of casualties suffered by the Confederates.

Seizing the advantage

Pope was startled to find the Confederates behind his front line, but their position was precarious, and he saw a chance for victory. With the Army of the Potomac arriving, Pope hoped to trap and annihilate Jackson's forces.

On August 27, Jackson withdrew from Manassas Junction, taking up a defensive position on a ridge at Groveton, near the 1861 Bull Run battlefield. If discovered, he knew he could not expect to hold out for long against Pope's reinforced army. Confederate support was arriving in the form of Longstreet's corps, with Lee in attendance, but Jackson was still alone when the fighting started in earnest.